

On the advice of a friend from Sierra Club Kim and I decided to hike the highest point in Big Bear Valley, Sugarloaf Mountain.

There were actually three different routes published on the Sierra Club HPS site. We had originally intended to do a shorter 6 mile route and possibly add a second peak after that. That required a bit of driving however and as we left Big Bear city we made a spontaneous decision to take the longer 8 mile route that began at Bear Mountain Ski Resort.

We didn't end up getting to the trailhead until a little before 10 am but looking at the write-up it didn't seem like it would be a problem. 8-ish miles and 2400' of climbing, no problem! (haha)



The route started out with a few miles on fire roads along the top of Bear Mountain Ski Resort. It was a gradual climb for most of the way but nothing too strenuous until we reached the hill called Sugarlump on the map (not to be confused with our target, Sugarloaf Mountain.)



This is the ski patrol hut on the top of Sugarlump which is also the Geronimo double black diamond ski slope. We would become more intimately familiar with it in about 8 hours.





From here on out we would be in true wilderness with a minimum of several hours hiking separating us from civilization / potential help. This is what we call fun. ☺

The mountain in the background is Sugarloaf, our goal. After descending a steep debris field we picked up a faint use trail and made out way along the ridge.



For those not familiar with the term use trail the above image shows a part of our route when we were still a ways away from Sugarloaf. The pile of rocks is called a trail duck and has been set up by previous hikers and lets you know you're following the "right" trail and not some random deer path (been there, done that.) As might be apparent the trail is not always trivial to follow but during the day it's not that big of a deal. We only



hit a few spots where I really had to hunt around to find where the trail continued and we could always see our destination looming ahead of us.



After several hours of hiking along the ridge and cresting rise after rise with Sugarloaf always appearing to be just over the next one we finally reached the mountain itself. The trail at this point became indistinct and quickly petered out completely as we started a steep climb through a variety of debris. This picture looking down on part of it really doesn't do the incline justice. I would actually count this as one of the harder climbs I've done. I'm used to steep climbs and I even enjoy them but this was more an exercise in trying to find stable footing. You could easily take one step and slide down two in places.

At this point it became obvious the route was significantly more difficult than the write-up suggested. Kim and I both knew we had several miles to cover to get back and that it was getting late in the afternoon but having come this far neither of us wanted to turn back without making the peak and signing the ever important peak log.





We eventually made the top. Once up there it is very difficult to tell where to head down again. I actually marked the descent from the saddle with one of my water bottles and we went up to the marked peak to find the peak log.

Peak logs are small notebooks usually sealed in PVC pipes or coffee cans which contain signatures and insightful comments about others who have made the peak. Sometimes there are hard to locate but here it was out in plain sight. There had actually been one other person up there that day but she had come from the easier route. Kim and I would not see another human being until we got back to Big Bear.

We ate a quick lunch and recovered for the long climb down while posing for a few pictures. At this point it is after 3 pm.









Returning to the saddle we picked up my water bottle and started to head down. This is a view from part way down the descent looking out at our return route. The ski slopes begin at the highest point along the nearest ridge.

The descent was arguably harder than the climb since debris kept sliding whenever you put your foot down and you constantly had to worry about falling or twisting your ankle. Also the time of day was becoming more of a pressing issue even though we knew we had several more hours of daylight.

We also missed the start of the use trail due to lack of navigation cues and had to do a bit of clambering through bushes to find it again but eventually we were back on the ridge moving as fast as we could back to the ski area.





The ridge was maddening in a way because we could see our goal the entire time and every time we crested a hill we hoped to see the chair lift on Sugarlump only to be faced with another hill. The sun was sinking rapidly by now and the use trail was obscure enough in places that I did not want to be out after dark.



Anyone who hikes with me knows I carry a rather large pack so worst case we could have safely if somewhat uncomfortably spent a night up there.



We had been hiking for quite a while at this point and the climb had taken it's toll.





Of course some of us are too stupid to care...





We did have quite a nice view of San Geronio to the south as the sun set.



We made it back to the top of Sugarlump just as the sun was going down. This was fortunate as I really did not want to try following that use trail in the dark. The temperature had also dropped quite a bit and most of my warmest gear was on Kim. While seeing if we could huddle in the doorway of the ski patrol hut to get out of the wind a bit I tried the door and found that the latch didn't catch.

We spent about 10 minutes inside catching our breath and warming up. Unfortunately no one arrived to arrest us or escort us off the property so we still had a few more miles to go to get back to my truck and we were rapidly losing the remaining daylight.





The remaining hike was on fire roads so we were able to increase our pace. We still ended up doing the last bit in near total darkness, especially when we were back inside the trees for the section as you leave Bear Mountain. One small flashlight between the two of you makes you very aware of how remote you are.

We arrived back at my truck at 7:30 pm. The hike had taken us over 9 hours due to our combined pace and the greater than expected difficulty.



Yaay! We lived! Time for Mexican food!

Then we had another fun task; driving out the maze of dirt roads that make up the Big Bear Back country trying to make out signs as we went.

All in all a rather memorable outing.





Approximate route in relation to Big Bear Lake.